



He will keep going for his shots. When he's in flow, he's just impossible to stop," Karmakar had told *Sportstar* a day before the final. But all that aggressiveness had its downside as well. "Just like you can't control a truck at high speed, it's hard for Kusale to control himself when things go wrong. But he's become more mature now and knows how to rein himself in," Karmakar said.

The version of Kusale who took the firing lane on the day of the final was exactly the one Karmakar had hoped to see. He was aggressive when necessary and restrained when he had to be, delivering a performance that made it hard to believe he was competing in his maiden Olympic Games — against the world's elite shooters.

Kusale was undoubtedly nervous. He began with a 9.6 in his first shot in the kneeling position of the final. In this event, shooters take 15 shots while kneeling, followed by 15 shots in the prone position, before transitioning to the standing position.

The first of two shooters are

eliminated after the initial two series of 10 shots in the standing position, with the next lowest-ranked shooter being eliminated after each subsequent shot. The occasion seemed overwhelming for Kusale, but he managed to maintain his composure.

At the end of the first two stages, he was in fifth place, 0.9 points behind fourth, and a full point away from the medals — a significant gap in a sport where matters are decided in decimals. Kusale said he wasn't paying attention to the gap. "I was just focusing on my breath and my body to calm myself," he said after the match.

Although he was trailing, the standing position — where shooters have the least stability while aiming at a target 50 metres away — is where matters are truly settled. And this is where Kusale really shone. Knowing he needed to make up that gap, he stayed aggressive.

Despite starting poorly with a 9.5 in his opening shot, he shot four more in the ten-ring to maintain his position. In his second series of five shots, a 9.1 was evened out by four

more tens.

As Kusale kept his nerve, those around him faltered. 2023 World silver medallist and European champion Jiří Přívratský of the Czech Republic, who was in fourth place, and 2022 World Championships gold medallist Jon-Hermann Hegg of Norway, who was in the lead at the start of the standing series, shot several nines, vaulting Kusale into the bronze medal position. The Indian never relinquished it, eventually opening up a 2.2-point gap that Přívratský couldn't close.

Kusale even had a chance to finish in second place but conceded that to Ukraine's Serhiy Kulish, eventually settling for bronze, a feat that brought a big smile to his face as he stood on the podium. He later said he still has more to achieve. "There's still a promise that I have left to fulfil," he says.

But that's for another day.

On the day he medalled, Kusale carried not just a mantra on his skin and the word 'Bharat' on his gun, but also the national flag on his back, looking every bit an icon of Indian sports.